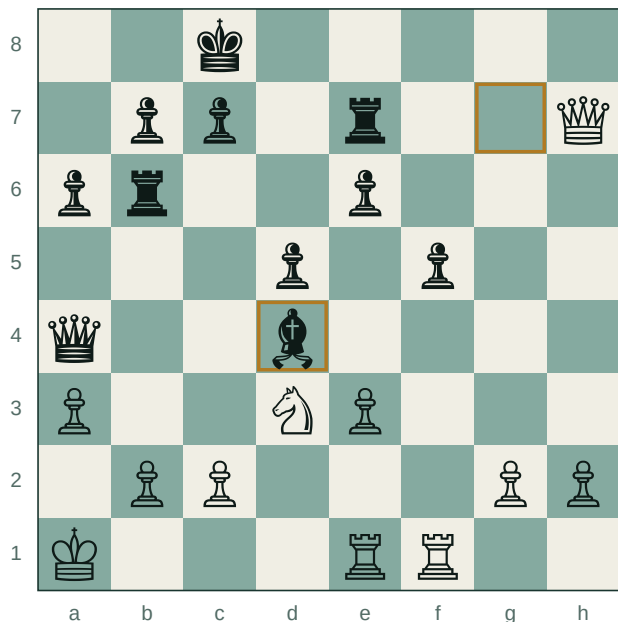


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 26

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 25...Bxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qxe7 Bxb2+ 27. Nxb2

26.Qxe7 The queen captures the rook on e7. Recorded reply: **26...Bxb2+**.

27.Nxb2 The knight captures the bishop on b2.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from +0 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on e7 and queen on a4. Check for tactical protection.